

IPL, now with a lighter bat

The Indian cricket board's **move** to **rein in** monster cricket bats — **going forward**, the **willows** used in the IPL should pass the **gauge** test — **was** a long **overdue** measure to restore the **skewed** balance in the game. Weight was never the issue. **Ironically**, modern-day bats are lighter than the ones used in the 20th century. But dimensions were a concern, especially the sweet spot, the thickness of the edges. Perfect balance might still be **elusive**. But cricket should take steps **whereby** mis-hits don't **soar** over the ropes and **mediocre** batsmen are not **hailed** as six-hitting T20 greats.

Bowlers who complain about the game's **blatant** unfairness **have** a point. The ball has remained much the same through centuries. Newer colours, machines replacing hands in stitching leather, and use of different **dyes**, are the only changes. **In contrast**, bats have evolved faster than **homo sapiens**. Thomas White, a Surrey batsman, used a bat as wide as the stumps, prompting the first restriction on the size of a bat. In subsequent years, batsmen have **wielded** a **spate** of fancily named bats, from the Jumbo and Run Reaper to Mongoose and the unpressed trampoline bats that modern cricketers use. Australia's **pace** legend Dennis Lillee once wielded an aluminium bat. Bat-making scientists are devoting endless nights to making bats lighter but more powerful. The **depth** of the bats **expanded** to such an extent that the MCC introduced restrictions in 2017 to **de-fatten** the wood.



It's **presumptuous** to believe that eliminating giant bats would reduce the **manic** frequency of sixes in the modern game. For, six-hitting is not an accidental **byproduct** of powerful bats alone. Other factors have contributed, like smaller ground dimensions and the expanding imagination of batsmen. The really good six-hitters will clear the **fence**, no matter the **checks** and **curbs**. In that sense, bat-gauges would help in **appreciating** their six-hitting **prowess** even more and separate the **upstarts** from the originals.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

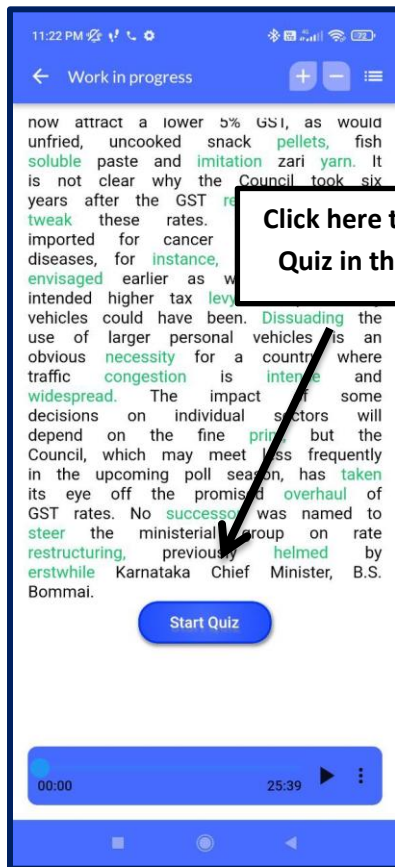
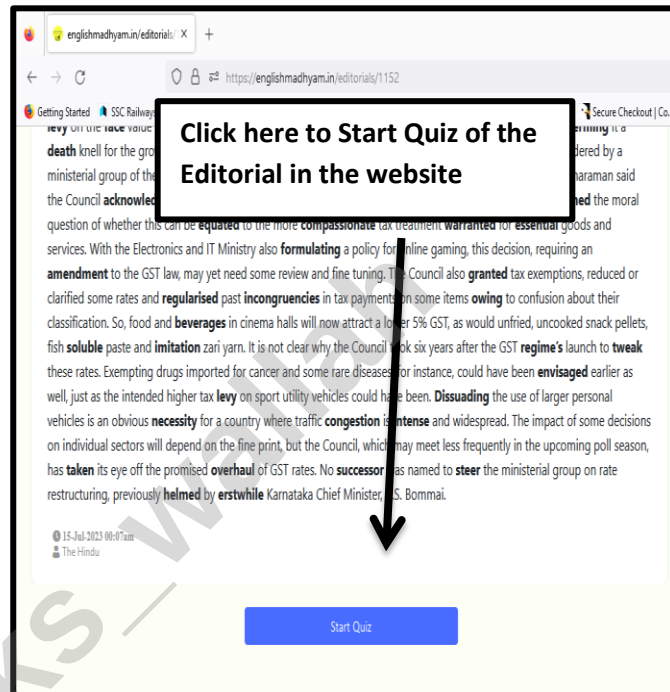
1. **Rein in** (phrasal verb) – control, restrain, limit, curb नियंत्रण करना
2. **Going forward** (phrase) – henceforth, from now on, in future, hereafter, moving ahead आगे चलकर
3. **Willows** (noun) – cricket bats, wooden blades, bat wood, equipment, gear बल्ले
4. **Gauge** (noun) – measure, standard, scale, instrument, benchmark मापने का यंत्र / मानक
5. **Overdue** (adjective) – delayed, late, pending, behind schedule, belated विलंबित / पहले ही हो जाना चाहिए था
6. **Skewed** (adjective) – unbalanced, biased, distorted, uneven, tilted असंतुलित
7. **Ironically** (adverb) – paradoxically, surprisingly, contrary to expectations, humorously, contradictorily विडंबना से
8. **Elusive** (adjective) – hard to catch, difficult, slippery, evasive, intangible मुश्किल से मिलने वाला
9. **Whereby** (adverb) – through which, by which, in which, using which, according to which जिसके द्वारा
10. **Soar** (verb) – rise, fly, ascend, rocket, increase तेजी से ऊपर जाना
11. **Mediocre** (adjective) – average, ordinary, unremarkable, second-rate, uninspired साधारण
12. **Hail** (verb) – praise, acclaim, salute, recognize, celebrate प्रशंसा करना
13. **Blatant** (adjective) – obvious, flagrant, overt, shameless, glaring ज़ाहिर / खुलेआम
14. **Dye** (noun) – coloring agent, pigment, tint, stain, hue रंग
15. **In contrast** (phrase) – on the other hand, however, conversely, whereas, differently इसके विपरीत
16. **Homo sapiens** (noun) – human beings, mankind, humans, species, humanity मनुष्य जाति
17. **Wield** (verb) – use, handle, operate, brandish, exercise उपयोग करना (जैसे हथियार या औज़ार)
18. **Spate** (noun) – series, flood, wave, succession, outbreak क्रम / अचानक बढ़ोत्तरी
19. **Pace** (noun) – speed, velocity, tempo, rate, momentum गति
20. **De-fatten** (verb) – slim down, reduce thickness, trim, thin, lighten पतला करना

21. **Presumptuous** (adjective) – arrogant, overconfident, bold, forward, audacious
दुस्साहसी / अति आत्मविश्वासी
22. **Maniac** (adjective) – excessive, frenzied, obsessive, crazed, wild उन्मत्त / पागलपन से भरा
23. **Byproduct** (noun) – secondary result, side effect, outcome, spin-off, consequence उप-उत्पाद
24. **Fence** (noun) – boundary, barrier, wall, enclosure, border बाड़
25. **Checks** (noun) – controls, limitations, restraints, inspections, boundaries नियंत्रण
26. **Curb** (noun) – limit, restraint, control, restriction, brake रोक / नियंत्रण
27. **Appreciate** (verb) – value, recognize, admire, respect, acknowledge सराहना करना
28. **Prowess** (noun) – skill, talent, expertise, ability, competence कौशल
29. **Upstart** (noun) – a person who has suddenly risen in rank and importance but behaves as if they are more important than other people, in a way that is annoying नया लेकिन घमंडी व्यक्ति

Summary of the Editorial

1. The Indian cricket board has decided to regulate bat dimensions in the IPL using a gauge test.
2. This move aims to restore balance between bat and ball, which had tilted in favor of batsmen.
3. The issue was never the weight of modern bats — they are actually lighter than older ones.
4. The concern lies in the thickness of edges and the enlarged sweet spot, aiding even mishits to clear boundaries.
5. The editorial argues that mediocre batsmen should not be glorified as T20 greats due to bat technology.
6. Bowlers' grievances about the unfairness of the game are valid — cricket balls haven't changed much over time.
7. Meanwhile, bats have evolved dramatically, often gaining advantages with each new innovation.
8. Historically, Thomas White's extra-wide bat led to the first ever bat size restriction in cricket.
9. Over the years, bats have had creative names like Jumbo, Run Reaper, Mongoose, and trampoline bats.
10. Innovations include aluminium bats (used once by Dennis Lillee) and scientifically engineered wood for power hitting.
11. Due to increasing bat depth, the MCC imposed restrictions in 2017 to reduce oversized bats.
12. The current rule changes won't eliminate sixes entirely, as power-hitting is not just about bat size.
13. Factors like smaller boundaries and batters' innovative techniques also fuel the rise of sixes.
14. Top-class batsmen will continue to hit sixes, regardless of bat limitations.
15. Bat-gauging will help highlight genuine talent in six-hitting and distinguish skilled players from opportunists.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based

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